Punctuations

Miss Alia Ismail

Functional English (SS1012)

What is Punctuation?

Punctuation refers to the marks and symbols used in written language to organize ideas, clarify meaning, and show pauses, relationships, or the end of sentences.

In simple words:

Punctuation tells the reader how to read and understand a sentence

Compare:

Let's eat, Grandma.

Let's eat Grandma.

Major Punctuation Marks

.	Period
,	Comma
?	Question Mark
!	Exclamation Mark
:	Colon
;	Semicolon

‘	Apostrophe
“ “	Quotation Mark
-	Hyphen
( )	Parenthesis
[ ]	Brackets
…..	Ellipsis

1:Full Stop / Period (.)

- A **full stop** marks the end of a complete declarative or imperative sentence.
- **Examples:**
  I live in Peshawar.
  Close the door.
- The full stop tells

  The thought is complete. Stop here.
- **It is also used in some abbreviations:**

  Dr.
  Mr.
  etc.

2:Comma (,)

The comma is probably the **most commonly misunderstood punctuation mark**.

A comma generally shows **separation within a sentence**, but it does **not** simply mean "pause wherever you breathe."

Uses of Comma

1:Separating items in a list

I bought apples, oranges, bananas, and grapes.

2: Separating introductory words or phrases

However, I decided to go.

After the class, we went home.

.

3: Direct address

Amjad, please listen.

The comma shows that **Amjad is being addressed**.

4: Joining two independent clauses with a coordinating conjunction

For example:

I wanted to go, but I was tired

3: Question Mark (?)

- A question mark is used at the end of a **direct question**.

  Where are you going?
- **Important:**
- A direct question gets a question mark:

  She asked, "Where are you going?"
- But an indirect question normally does not:

  She asked where I was going.

  Why?

4:Exclamation Mark (!)

- The exclamation mark expresses **strong emotion, surprise, excitement, anger, emphasis, etc.**

  Example: What a beautiful day!

- **Academic writing**

  Avoid excessive use of exclamation marks in formal academic writing.

5:Semicolon (;)

- A semicolon is stronger than a comma but weaker than a full stop.
- It can connect two closely related independent clauses.
- Example: I was tired; I continued working.

6:Colon (:)

A colon usually explains, illustrates, or lists things

- **Use 1: Introducing a list**

  I need three things: a pen, a notebook, and a book.

- **Use 2: Introducing an explanation**

  She had one goal: to pass the examination.

- **Use 3: Introducing an example**

  He had one major problem: he lacked confidence.

Important rule

- Usually, don't put a colon directly after a verb when the sentence structure doesn't require it.

- The three things I need are: a pen, a book, and a notebook. (Incorrect)

Better:

- The three things I need are a pen, a book, and a notebook.

Or:

- I need three things: a pen, a book, and a notebook.

7:Apostrophe (')

The apostrophe has **two major functions**.

Function 1: Possession

- It shows that something belongs to someone or something.

- Hoorain's book.

  The book belongs to Hoorain.

Singular noun:

- the student's book

Plural noun ending in s:

- the students' books

Notice the difference:

- **student's** = one student
  students' = more than one student

Continue…Function 2: Contractions

An apostrophe shows that letters have been omitted.

- do not → don't
- cannot → can't
- I am → I'm
- she is → she's

8:Quotation Marks (" ")

- Quotation marks are used mainly to indicate **direct speech or quoted material**.

  Example: She said, "I am tired."

- The exact words spoken are inside quotation marks.

9:Hyphen (-)

A hyphen joins words or parts of words.

- Examples:

- well-known writer
- part-time job
- twenty-one

10:Parentheses ( )

Parentheses contain **additional or supplementary information**.

- Example: William Shakespeare (1564–1616) is one of the most influential writers in English literature.

11:Brackets [ ]

- Brackets are often used inside quotations to add or clarify information that was **not part of the original quotation**.
- Example: She stated that “They[the students] need more practice."

12:Ellipsis (…)

An ellipsis indicates **omission, trailing off, hesitation, or an unfinished thought**, depending on context.

- Example: I thought I knew the answer, but…

Activity

- yesterday our teacher announced an english speech competition every student was encouraged to participate are you ready to speak in front of the class she asked i wanted to volunteer but I hesitate i was not sure if i could speak confidently finally i raised my hand and said yes i will participate my classmates encouraged me their support gave me the confidence to do my best

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